port of disembarkation and a ‘protector of emigrants’ at the port of embarkation. The latter now survives as a department in India’s ministry of external affairs. As per an Act of 1844, the protector of emigrants would ensure that ‘no emigrant shall embark without a certificate from the Agent, countersigned by the Protector’ leading to a curious phrase that is now imprinted in Indian passports as ‘Emigration Check Not Required’.[71] After frequent protests and a long-protracted debate led by Indian political leaders, indenture was abolished to give way to the Emigration Act of 1922, which was again replaced in 1983 to govern contemporary labour emigration.

In the late 19th century, with better regulations and word of mouth advertisement of returning emigrants, indenture transformed into a kith-kin based system of migration that would be the hallmark of the Great Indian Migration Wave.[72] It is also worth emphasizing that indentured migration formed less than 10 per cent of all work-related migration during its period of existence.[73] Indenture has been seen as a ‘new system of slavery’ by some but was also an escape from an older system of slavery or domestic bondage induced by caste, and other pressures.[74] This is why the abolishment of the system did not stop migration from the key recruiting districts as they continued to supply migrants to different places for another 100 years.

The dominant form of labour recruitment of the Great Indian Migration Wave in the late 19th and early 20th century was through a contractor, with a wide-ranging nomenclature. Called Kangany in Ceylon and Malaya, Maistry in Burma, Sardar in other places, or Jobber in English, he would often be a production site foreman, labour recruiter and community headman who would bring in people from his village or neighbourhood to the doorstep of his employer, be it a mine, mill, port or plantation.[75] He spoke the same language as the labourers and had the confidence of capitalists. He could be a saviour, in which case his role would survive for decades, and in other places he would turn out to be a debt-raking villain leading to his eviction. Elements of this figure still survive in many seasonal migration streams in contemporary India, but for the most part, the